Los Angeles Times

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KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

WAVES CRASH against East Seaside Walk in Long Beach on Sunday as homes collapse on the peninsula.

Raman's views are strong, if not always fixed

Mayoral candidate has reversed on issues including no-camping zones, police funding.

BY DAVID ZAHNISER

Los Angeles City Councilmember Nithya Raman has routinely opposed efforts by her colleagues to block homeless encampments in their districts, voting more than 60 times since 2021 against measures to ban them near schools, libraries, parks, freeway overpasses and other public areas.

After announcing her bid for mayor, however, Raman took a sharp turn on the issue.

"When I'm mayor, if the council wants to create new [no camping] zones, I'm not going to stand in the way," she told an audience in May.

Add the no-camping turnabout to a list of political issues on which Raman took one position only to later shift her stance — or in some cases, reverse it completely.

During her first run for City Council in 2020, Raman called for the defunding of the police, telling her followers that "the path is not complicated." Two years later, she voted for a nearly 3% increase in spending on the Los Angeles Police Department, allocating an additional $82 million.

Raman urged voters in 2022 to approve Measure ULA, the tax on real estate sales above $5.4 million, dubbed by some as the "mansion tax." On social media, she downplayed warnings that the tax would discourage apartment construction, saying the impact would be "very minor."

The council member later changed course, saying the tax has had a disastrous effect on apartment construction and desperately needs an overhaul. "You can't address a housing crisis with a policy that worsens our housing shortage," Raman said in January.

Raman also voted this

[See **Raman,** A7]

Trump's border plan has hit a wall in Texas

Landowners are defying his signature project after a judge pauses construction.

BY REBECCA SANTANA

RUIDOSA, Texas — Across the southern border, the Trump administration has been moving ahead with a $46-billion border wall project.

But in Texas' Big Bend region, it has run up against intense opposition from landowners. That resistance is complicating President Trump's signature infrastructure project in a fight that has become a test of just how far his administration will go to fulfill his vision of a fortified southern border.

The federal government has sweeping authority to force the project through. But a judge has now paused construction across the region, giving a major boost to landowners who have sought to impede the wall by refusing to cooperate with government surveyors, protesting at county meetings and gearing up for court battles.

"Landowner resistance has slowed this project to a crawl," said David Keller, a landowner suing to stop the Big Bend border projects. The administration, he added, was "woefully unprepared for the hornet's nest they stirred up."

Building a wall along the U.S.-Mexico border has long been a key campaign promise for Trump. Republicans last year approved money for the project as part of an immigration enforcement package.

The administration says that even with illegal immigration plummeting, the border project is needed to keep the numbers low.

Customs and Border Protection says it's building 12 miles of barrier a week. On Friday, the agency said it's built over 260 miles of border barriers under the second Trump administration: "CBP is on track and constructing border barrier faster than ever," the agency said in a statement.

In Big Bend, where construction began in September, the administration plans to spend $7.5 billion to fortify the border along a region stretching more than 500 miles.

In August, the Border Patrol arrested 8,870 people along the southern border. In Big Bend, which makes up roughly one-quarter of the entire U.S.-Mexico border, it arrested about 160 people.

"The American people

[See **Border,** A6]

Rachel soaks Southwest, but coast catches a break

Damage to Southland beaches was less than feared

BY FEDOR ZARKHIN, DEBORAH VANKIN, RUBEN VIVES AND JENNY JARVIE

Wide swaths of the Southwest were deluged Sunday as the remnants of Tropical Storm Rachel weakened and moved inland, but coastal communities already battered by high surf emerged with less damage than some officials feared.

The National Weather Service said Sunday morning that Rachel was no longer a tropical storm. But danger remained as waves crashed into beachfront homes in Long Beach, large rocks and mud hurtled down a mountain onto a highway south of Palm Desert, and floodwater submerged the parking lot of a casino on the Las Vegas Strip.

While the downgrading of Sunday's storms brought some relief, risks continue across the California coast until Tuesday, and there is the longer-term concern of what is expected to be an active El Niño season.

"We're not out of the woods yet," National Weather Service meteorologist Daniel Berc said Sunday morning. Although the heaviest rain is over, according to meteorologists with the National Weather Service, people across the Southwest can expect spotty rain and high tides for the next couple of days.

On Sunday, some of the worst damage on the California coast was on the Long Beach Peninsula.

After tides swept away a portion of Long Beach's historic wooden boardwalk Saturday, waves of saltwater rolled into a yellow two-story

[See **Rachel,** A6]

SIMON LASHES TOWNS: Hurricane pounds Mexico's Pacific coast. **WORLD, A3**
ISAIAS SATURATES: Florida and Alabama clean up after big storm. **NATION, A5**

Hilton courting the discontented

The Republican is dodging Trump while seeking his voters in his bid for governor.

BY HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

In rural Modoc County, in California's remote northeast corner, Republican gubernatorial candidate Steve Hilton donned a beige cowboy hat and climbed atop a horse.

Riding through a grassy field, with his dress shoes in the stirrups, Hilton lamented to a camera that California was "completely being ruined by killjoy bureaucrats" who put too many rules on fun stuff like beach fire pits and bars that stay open extra late.

In coastal San Luis Obispo County, Hilton boarded a bright yellow dune buggy at the Oceano Dunes State Vehicular Recreation Area and called the California Coastal Commission "idiots" for trying to end off-road beach driving.

And in the Central Valley, he waved the ceremonial green flag at a stock car race at the Madera Speedway, where he was named grand marshal of the annual Harvest Classic. (The designation caused a minor uproar, prompting the operator of the racetrack to make a fake online concession menu that offered a hot dog and soda for $6 for Republicans and $17.50 for Democrats.)

If it seems like Hilton — the British immigrant and former Fox News talk show host — is just about everywhere, taking just about every media interview that comes his way, well, that's the point, he says.

He has logged thousands of miles on the proverbial campaign trail, visiting all 58 counties in his quest to lead

[See **Hilton,** A5]

How L.A. became a turtle smuggling hub

Ojai conservancy's role expands as illegal trafficking has climbed

BY STUART MILLER



JULIE LEOPO For The Times

ERIC GOODE, founder of the Turtle Conservancy in Ojai, chronicled reptile smuggling in an HBO series.

Turtles and tortoises are coming to Los Angeles from all over America, but it's happening against their will. Smuggling these creatures for overseas sales, especially in Asia, began growing rapidly at the turn of this century, but there has been a dramatic increase in the last six or seven years, and LAX and the ports of Los Angeles and Long Beach are major exit points.

Eric Goode, founder of the Turtle Conservancy in Ojai, knows this issue all too well.

Founded in 2005, the 90-acre conservancy originally focused on helping create or maintain habitats around the world and serving as a research center, but these days much of its energy goes to caring for the displaced turtles and tortoises, most of which arrive starving and stressed. The conservancy, whose mission has expanded to deal with the growing tide of animals that need help, has taken in 810 turtles and tortoises saved by authorities since 2017. More than 400 of those have been in the last six months.

"We're at a breaking

[See **Turtle,** A12]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

ACTOR Bella Mraz stars in the microseries "Hollywood Starlet," which is designed for phone watching.

Betting big on dramas for the smallest screens

BY CERYS DAVIES

On the set of CBS' legacy soap opera "The Bold and the Beautiful" at the Sunset Las Palmas Studios in Hollywood, two actors were caught in a fiery exchange.

"Do you want to know where Jack was last night?" actor Skyla Lynne asked with a sly grin. "He was with me."

From behind a monitor displaying a vertically oriented feed, the director interjected: "Could you pause a bit more in between those lines? We might want to do an episode break there."

The scene wasn't for an episode of the soap opera. It was part of the 40-episode second season of "Hollywood Starlet," a new microdrama series from "The Bold and the Beautiful" head writer Bradley Bell and his son Oliver.

"I've been doing soap operas my whole life, and it felt like there's been a buzz about microdramas, and it really felt like a natural extension to the stories that we do," Bradley Bell said. "[On soap operas] we build two cliffhangers usually on Fridays to keep the viewers over the weekend. Here, you do it

[See **Microdramas,** A10]

Mismanagement of jail is alleged
Family files a wrongful-death claim after man was found unresponsive in cell at Twin Towers facility. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Her recipe for inspiration
Singer Victoria Monét wanted a new way to channel her creativity. She found it in cooking. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
A couple of showers. L.A. Basin: 68/56. **B6**



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

WINLESS, TIMES 5

Quarterback Justin Herbert and the Chargers are tripped up by the Denver Broncos 23-17 to fall to 0-5 in what's becoming a lost season. **SPORTS, D1**